

To imagination and beyond



Jayesh Shinde
Manager - Test Centre
jayesh.shinde@digit.in

"Before technology became mainstream, when it was brand new, every little iterative evolution of gizmo, gadgets and technological breakthrough seemed like the next best thing."

Hearing can be as good as seeing sometimes, especially if it's something said by a person you trust. The idea for this column came about in a conversation I had with Anirudh and Kunal, both of whom visited Taipei last month to cover Computex 2014.

According to both of them, and people they met during the course of their Taipei visit, the scope of Computex had drastically reduced from the previous year. Curiously enough I had heard similar undertones of shrinking glory from exhibitors and event veterans that I encountered at Computex 2013. "It's not the same as it was back in the day," is a statement I heard from several event regulars; it's something Anirudh and Kunal heard a lot this year as well. Mithun's experience of the India Gadget Expo held in Hyderabad also left a lot to be desired – if this was the best India could showcase, then heaven save our souls!

Looking at these personal experiences, it's hard not to conclude that mega events aren't just that mega anymore. Probably they're still huge when it comes to scale and volume of products on display and companies exhibiting under one roof, but they just don't have compelling products to excite people anymore. All you're treated to are minor enhancements in a product or technology, nothing that grabs your eyeballs and sows the seed of something truly pathbreaking. It's more evolutionary than revolutionary.

Languishing in the cesspool of mediocrity are we? Not at all. In fact, humans today are arguably caught in the best phase of innovation than they've ever been in their entire existence – we're living in the digital era after all – and everyone's caught in a rat-race to out-innovate each other. My problem is only with the scale of innovation that we're concentrating on.

Everyone's playing for the next quarterly report. Today's digital architects aren't doing something, building something different that has far-reaching effects and the capacity to knock your socks off. And that's a real shame.

Before technology became mainstream, when it was brand new, every little iterative evolution of gizmo, gadgets and technological breakthrough seemed like the next best thing. My first PC had 64MB of RAM and the jump to 256MB RAM seemed as worthy an accomplishment as reaching the moon. However, the phone that I use has more RAM than my laptop

from 2008, and I don't remember getting any kick out of it. Because I didn't feel my phone was doing something extraordinary; that it was following a path of tech evolution that was laid before it several years ago. There was no wow factor. And I'm not alone to share this view about the ever-expanding world of tech as it touches every facet of our life. It's doing what it's supposed to do, what's there to harp about?

Extraordinary. In one word, that's what the technology world is lacking. Some of its sheen has worn off and tech has become ordinary because it's entering areas of our existence that we knew it would enter – through sci-fi books, companies' roadmaps, public disclosures, etc. That's what is evident through gadget shows, tech expos and company announcements over the last few years. All glitter and glamour, very little substance, and no vision to speak about.

Revolutionary, not evolutionary; radical changes, not iterative enhancements; that's what is required to rekindle our faith in the fact that we can dream and achieve great things through tech again, and not just focus our energies in making things faster, lighter, smaller, efficient, and all that jazz.

Renowned astrophysicist and now a popular television personality, Dr. Neil Degraesse Tyson argued in front of the US Senate in 2012 for bolstering NASA's budget and not clipping its wings by saying something very poignant, "The only people doing much dreaming back then (re: early space exploration era) were scientists, engineers, and technologists. Their visions of tomorrow derive from their formal training as discoverers." While technology has become mainstream and touched every facet our life, we lack genuine discoverers (perhaps with the exception of Elon Musk) amidst ourselves who can show us a great vision of what revolutionary change looks like rather than shovel iterative jazz that we've become so habituated to.

You never know how it could impact our lives, if that were to happen. If nothing else, at least we'd have much more exciting tech expos. And wouldn't that be a sight to behold! 